Network, DSL Systems and several other solutions. TeNet then collaborates with R&D organisations to implement projects that develop versatile and low-cost projects beneficial to rural India, using these ICTs.

Logging On

Chennai-based n-Logue, a company incubated by TeNet, aims to install and operate telephone and Internet connections in every Indian village. n-Logue identifies and trains potential kiosk owners and also supplies them with the necessary infrastructure—hardware, battery backup, wireless Internet antenna, etc. The company also helps the kiosk owners arrange for loans, which are repaid with revenue from the kiosks. n-Logue makes its money from hourly connection fees.

Abdul Razzak owns two Internet kiosks in Melur, Madurai, and has been an entrepreneur for three years now. Says Razzak, "I teach computer courses such as Java, etc, at rates much cheaper than those in the city." A typical 'Office Tools' course, for example, would cost only Rs 300 at his kiosk, while it could cost four times as much in Chennai.

Shalini, from Pinjavakkam village, Tiruvallur district, Tamil Nadu, was introduced to n-Logue by her mother, a social worker. Shalini has done a secretarial course from a school in Chennai, and is currently pursuing a Bachelor of Arts degre throught a correspondence course. She is also in charge of the sole Internet kiosk in Pinjavakkam. This income helps support her family.

In Tiruvallur, the Internet is mainly used as a tool for education; not just for children, but also for adults. "Now we don't have to go to the city to study. We can stay here and educate ourselves," says Shalini.

Through video conferencing, people address their problems directly to the District Collector.

Suganya of T Ulagapitchanpatti village in Melur taluka, has been a kiosk owner for two years now. She was part of a self-help group when she got onto the ICT bandwagon. She says the kiosks have helped farmers seek advice on crop-related problems from the Agricultural University, and on veterinary problems from the Tamil Nadu Veterinary and Animal Science University (TANUVAS), Chennai, using a Web cam and video conferencing facilities. Chat is popular at her kiosk too. "On Fridays we have a Dubai chat session, and on Sundays we have a Denmark chat session," she says.

Says Dr Jhunjhunwala, "The SARI model has grown to over 30 districts and is expanding quickly." He believes the Internet can be used to double the per-capital GDP of rural India.

Says Joseph Thomas, Project Manager, SARI (IIT-Madras), "Raising the GDP is brought about collectively by using the Internet to encourage micro-enterprise in the village, providing better marketing channels for village produce, getting expert advice on agriculture and veterinary sciences, and a lot of new financial services."

"Farmers are able to seek advice on crop-related problems... and on veterinary problems, using the Web cam and video conferencing facilities.

Suganya, Melur

How SARI Benefits

Education is the primary area of benefit—children from the age of six to 16 are made computer literate. Computer courses are offered at cheap rates; vocational training is provided to write resumes, applying to colleges and jobs, and in improving language skills. TeNet has also developed an application that lets students take sample tests online, prior to board exams, and receive feedback.

Farmers growing perishable crops such as flowers, or groundnuts, obtain market prices and sell their produce via the Internet. They also get weather and soil-related information online from national agencies. Web cam and video conferencing facilities are also used to obtain health-related advice from leading medical institutions.

The Road Ahead

The Melur project has achieved 'self-sustaining' status, and SARI has now moved on to other districts in Tamil Nadu, and other states as well.

According to S Madhu, Manager (Marketing and Training), n-Logue, "We are working with the Gujarat government to connect 16 districts under the 'Gyan Ganga' project. We are collaborating with Gujarat Informatics Limited to connect all districts—five are already networked—and develop local language content."

IT for development may seem like a misnomer, but projects like SARI have attempted to harness technology to create better economic opportunities for India's rural populace.

Make way! ■

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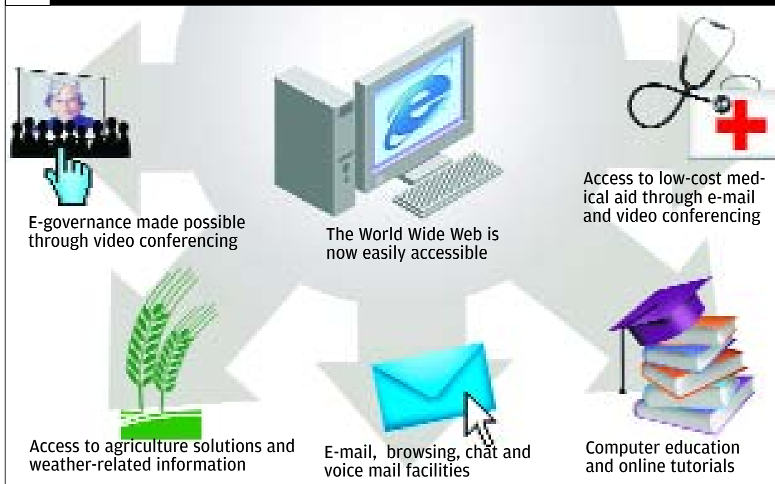
And This Is How The Villagers Benefit



How SARI Works

SARI was possible due to corDECT, a Wireless Local Loop technology, jointly developed by Analog Devices, Midas Communication Technologies, and the TeNeT group. corDECT provides cost-effective, high-quality voice and data connectivity, both in urban and rural areas: voice communication using 32 Kbps ADPCM, and Internet connectivity at 35 or 70 Kbps.

A fibre optic line is deployed to connect the local exchange with a central office terminal, which, in turn, is connected to a few remote terminals. Conventional copper wire is then used to link subscribers to the remote terminal near them.

The scheme supports star and ring topological networks, and promises high-quality voice and data transfer, with an ability to cater to nearly 8,000 subscribers per sq km. This scheme also supports advanced Network Management System features, and is compatible with emerging technologies such as high bit-rate and asynchronous digital subsrciber lines and of course, corDECT.

Source: http://www.tenet.res.in/